

CHAPTER 39 — The Match

Wednesday morning, Zoe opened the part she had refused to read.

Not because she wanted to.

That seemed unlikely to happen.

She had simply reached the point where not knowing had become worse.

The guesthouse room outside Hereford was too small for the amount of information sitting inside it.

Two chairs.

A narrow table.

Curtains thick enough to make nine in the morning look like six.

The archive laptop between her and Elias.

The backpack beside her feet.

Zoe opened the household record.

RCP-0193

Helen and Brian.

She had already decided what she would not open.

No photographs.

No private medical details beyond what actually explained their decision.

No dead child's name.

No letters.

No intimate family history just because the system had been disgusting enough to collect it.

She looked at Elias.

"Motive first." He nodded. No checklist. No argument. Zoe opened the summary. Three words appeared.

BEREAVEMENT

INFERTILITY FAILED LAWFUL ADOPTION

She stopped. She had expected something like that. Expectation turned out to be useless.

* * *

The first line underneath was worse.

BIOLOGICAL CHILD — DECEASED

No name. Good. Zoe did not need one. She stared at the words. Then asked: "How old?" Elias looked at her. She knew what he was checking.

Whether the answer mattered.

"It matters to the match."

He opened only the minimum field.

AGE AT DEATH: 4

Zoe closed it immediately.

Four.

A little girl.

Not an idea.

Not previous bereavement.

A four-year-old daughter who had existed in Helen and Brian's house before Zoe ever did.

Zoe sat back.

For some reason she thought of the cupboard under the stairs.

Old board games.

A broken vacuum cleaner.

A Christmas tree Brian complained about every December and refused to replace.

Had there once been different things in there?

Different shoes by the door?

Different drawings on the fridge?

She pushed the questions away.

They did not matter.

The next line concerned Helen.

The record did not need to show Zoe a diagnosis.

She refused to open it.

The consequence was enough.

After their daughter died, Helen learned that another pregnancy would not be considered safe.

After that came grief support.

Medical appointments.

Family counselling.

Then, years later, Helen and Brian tried to adopt.

Lawfully.

Properly.

They applied.

They were assessed.

They were refused.

Not necessarily forever.

At that time.

The reasons were summarised.

Unresolved grief.

Temporary financial instability.

And:

CONCERN REGARDING REPLACEMENT DYNAMICS

Zoe read that one twice.

“Replacement.”

Elias said nothing.

She looked at him.

“They were worried Helen and Brian wanted another child to replace the one who died.”

“That is what the summary says.”

Zoe looked back at the screen.

That did not make Helen evil.

Or Brian.

It made them grieving.

It made them people who desperately wanted something the lawful process had decided they were not ready for.

Zoe understood wanting the answer to be different.

She had spent most of the last few weeks doing exactly that.

The difference was what happened next.

* * *

Four months after the adoption decision, Mac appeared.

Not Mac in the file.

AC019

The sponsor.

The entry beneath him was short.

RELATIONSHIP: PRE-EXISTING — MALE APPLICANT

Brian.

Zoe frowned.

“So Brian knew him already.”

“Yes.”

“How?”

“Not necessary.”

“Agreed.”

She did not care whether they had met through business, football, a pub, a friend or some boring adult event involving name badges.

The important part was simpler.

Mac had not searched the country for grieving strangers.

He had already known Brian.

He had known enough to approach them after the lawful route failed.

The private pathway was explained.

Then the record showed:

RECIPIENT WITHDRAWAL

Zoe leaned closer.

A summary underneath explained why.

Brian had objected.

Not Helen.

Brian.

He had questioned legality.

Where the child would come from.

Whether a family could later challenge the placement.

Whether they had any right to participate in something outside the normal adoption process.

Zoe looked at Elias.

"Brian said no."

"At that stage."

She nodded.

Important distinction.

The household withdrew.

Four days later:

SPONSOR CONTACT — AC019

Then:

REOPEN REQUEST — APPLICANT B

Helen.

Zoe felt the answer before she finished reading it.

"Her."

"Yes."

"Helen reopened it."

"Yes."

After Mac called.

The file contained a short motive update.

Zoe hesitated.

This one mattered.

She opened only the summary.

Helen's circumstances had not changed.

The lawful route had not reopened.

But Helen now argued that their ability to give a child a permanent, stable, loving home should matter more than the barrier preventing them from doing so.

Zoe stared at the sentence.

It was not cruel.

That made it worse.

Helen had not written:

I deserve a child.

She had written something much easier to believe about yourself.

We can give a child a good home.

Zoe rubbed her thumb along the edge of the table.

"She thought being a good mum made breaking the rules okay."

Elias did not answer immediately.

Then:

"That is close to what the record supports."

"Close enough."

He let her have it.

Zoe did not write anything down.

She did not need to.

* * *

The next stage removed the possibility that Helen and Brian believed

they were simply using an unusual adoption agency.

The disclosures were clear enough.

The child would come from an existing safeguarding pathway.

Whatever process involving the child's original family was happening might not be finished.

Records would be changed.

Direct contact with the child's origin family would be restricted.

Legal vulnerability could remain later.

Zoe read each line once.

She had what she needed.

"They knew there might still be a family process."

"Yes."

"They knew this wasn't normal adoption."

"Yes."

"They knew records would be changed."

"Yes."

She waited.

Elias did not add anything.

Good.

The file did not prove Helen and Brian knew a specific parent had met reunification conditions.

It did not prove they knew a court record would be manipulated.

It did not prove they understood the entire shadow route.

But it also did not allow the cleaner story.

They had not simply been handed a child and lied to about everything.

They knew enough to know there was a line.

Brian had seen it.

Helen had seen it.

They crossed it anyway.

Zoe closed that section.

“Next.”

* * *

Suitability.

The archive loved Helen and Brian.

That was almost funny.

Almost.

Stable marriage.

Ordinary jobs.

Ordinary house.

No criminal history.

No violence.

No serious substance problems.

Quiet neighbourhood.

Good school nearby.

Low public profile.

Small social circle.

Nothing that would make people look twice.

Zoe stared at the summary.

“They wanted boring.”

“Apparently.”

“We were incredibly boring.”

“Apparently.”

She smiled despite herself.

Helen complaining every Thursday that nobody else on the street understood recycling.

Brian washing the car on Sunday mornings regardless of weather.

The argument about whether milk counted as something you should automatically replace when you finished it.

Christmas cards from neighbours they barely knew.

The radiator that made noises Brian insisted were normal.

The bathroom cabinet he fixed three times.

Ordinary.

Painfully ordinary.

The kind of house where a child could grow up for five years and nobody would ever think to ask whether the beginning had been legal.

Zoe looked at the stability rating again.

“The better we looked like a normal family, the safer the lie was.”

Elias looked at her.

“Yes.”

That one hurt.

Because the family had been normal.

Not fake-normal.

Real-normal.

Helen had really packed lunches.

Brian had really checked whether Zoe had done her homework.

The system had not manufactured those things.

It had simply understood that if those things happened, nobody would look underneath them.

* * *

The preference section was shorter.

Female child. Young enough for a long-term family placement. No highly complex care requirements. Broad physical compatibility with the household. Dark hair. Then:

FAMILIAL RESEMBLANCE: DESIRED

Zoe stopped moving. Traffic passed outside. A pipe knocked somewhere in the wall. Somebody closed a door downstairs. All of it seemed very far away. "Familial." "Yes." "Whose family?" Elias did not pretend not to know. "Likely their daughter." Zoe opened the definition. A term appeared.

PRIOR-CHILD ANCHOR: ACTIVE

She had seen the mechanism before. On somebody else. It had been horrible then.

Now it was hers. The system had recorded characteristics of Helen and Brian's daughter. Not her name. Characteristics. Hair. General face shape. A crooked smile. More detail waited underneath. Zoe stopped. "No."

Elias closed it. Immediately. She had seen enough. "They measured her face."

"Yes."

"And compared children to it."

"Yes."

"Including me."

"Yes."

Zoe put both hands flat on the table. The number she had already seen waited lower in the file. 97 It had meant nothing before.

High compatibility. Strong fit. A score. Now she understood what had contributed to it. Not only appearance. The system had also considered temperament. Household preferences. The likelihood of attachment. Whether the placement was expected to hold. But resemblance had been one of the strongest factors. Zoe looked at the number. "Ninety-seven."

"Yes."

"Because I looked like her."

"Partly."

She turned. "Partly?"

"The record supports resemblance as a major factor. Not the only factor."

Zoe stared at him. Then nodded. "Okay."

She hated the qualification. She needed it anyway.

The system had not searched for an identical child.

It had searched for familiarity.

Enough resemblance to hit an old wound.

Enough compatibility to make the rest easier.

And suddenly memories Zoe had stored for years rearranged themselves.

Helen looking at her across the kitchen.

Not often.

Just sometimes.

A strange expression.

Happy and sad at once.

A framed photograph that had disappeared from the lounge when Zoe was very young.

A girl Zoe had assumed was some relative nobody talked about.

Brian once starting:

"You've got the same stubborn mouth as—"

Then stopping.

Zoe had forgotten that.

No.

She had not forgotten it.

She had kept it without knowing what it meant.

Meaning arrived now.

"They chose someone who looked like her."

"Yes."

"Me."

Elias said nothing. Zoe looked again at ninety-seven. "They made me feel familiar before they knew me." That sentence left the room with nowhere to go.

* * *

There had been other possible children. Zoe did not open them. She did not need names. Or outcomes. Or reasons. The record only needed to establish that the system had searched. Compared. Matched. Then reached Zoe.

A17-04221

MATCH SCORE: 97

STATUS: PRESENT

Present. Zoe hated the word. Not meet. Not introduce. Present. Like a file on a table.

She moved lower.

Then stopped.

Another section waited.

P3 — CONTROLLED VISUAL INTRODUCTION

She already knew what came after that in the timeline.

A hold.

Three hours.

Acceptance.

But the household file had taught her something.

Sometimes knowing a door existed did not mean you should open it immediately.

Zoe closed the section.

Elias looked at her.

“Not today?”

“Not yet.”

No argument.

The evidence had answered enough.

Why Helen and Brian had been vulnerable.

Why Mac could reach them.

Why the household appealed to the system.

Why Zoe had been selected.

Why ninety-seven.

How Helen and Brian first saw her belonged to a different question.

And she was not ready to turn it into another field.

* * *

Outside, the air was cold enough to sting. Zoe preferred it. They followed a muddy footpath behind the guesthouse. Bare trees. Wet grass. A dog barking behind a fence. No laptop. No archive. For a while neither spoke. Then Zoe said: "She loved me because I looked like her."

Elias stopped. "No."

Zoe stopped too. "What?"

"You said Helen loved you because you looked like her."

"Yes."

"The file does not prove that."

"It proves she wanted someone who did."

"At the beginning."

"Same thing."

"No."

Zoe stared at him.

He did not move.

"Looking like her might explain why Helen felt something immediately," he said. "It does not explain five years."

"That sounds like defending her."

"It isn't."

"It sounds like it."

"Five years still happened."

Zoe looked away.

Elias continued.

"Resemblance did not make your lunches."

She said nothing.

"It did not attend school meetings."

Nothing.

"It did not sit beside you when you were sick. It did not argue with you. It did not learn what makes you angry."

"Most things."

"I noticed."

She almost smiled.

Almost.

He continued:

"It did not know you."

That was harder.

Zoe kicked a stone off the path.

"So the system used something horrible to start something real."
"Yes." "And then the real thing helped hide the horrible part." "Yes."
"That is disgusting." "Yes." "Good." Elias looked at her. "What?" "You agreed normally." "I do occasionally." "Rare." They walked on.

* * *

Helen spent the same morning in the loft. She had gone up looking for nothing. That was the lie she told herself. Brian found her standing beneath the hatch with the ladder down. "What are you doing?" Helen did not answer. He looked up. Then understood. "No."

She climbed anyway.

The box sat behind Christmas decorations and a suitcase neither of them had used in years.

Blue plastic.

Dust around the lid.

Helen brought it down.

Brian watched.

Neither said its name.

They carried it into the bedroom.

Helen sat on the floor.

Brian remained standing until that became ridiculous, then sat opposite her.

"I don't want to do this," he said.

"Then don't."

He stayed.

Helen opened the box.

Photographs.

A birthday card.

A hospital wristband.

One small red shoe.

Only one.

Helen stared at it.

Years earlier, the other had disappeared somewhere between the hospital, the funeral and the period afterward when objects seemed to move through the house without either of them remembering touching them.

She moved nothing.

Then Brian saw the photograph.

Park.

Climbing frame.

Their daughter laughing.

Dark hair.

Narrow face.

A smile that pulled slightly more on one side.

Helen picked it up.

Brian closed his eyes.

"She looked like her."

"Helen."

"She did."

"I know."

They had both known.

That was the truth sitting between them.

They had simply spent five years refusing to place the two girls side by side.

The photographs from before had gradually moved upstairs after Zoe arrived.

Not in one dramatic purge.

One frame replaced.

One box moved.

One picture removed because Helen cried every time she passed it.

Then another.

Eventually the dead child lived mostly in storage and memory.

Helen looked at the photograph.

"We told ourselves it meant something."

Brian opened his eyes.

"Mac never said it did."

“He didn’t have to.”

Brian looked away.

Helen touched the edge of the photograph.

“We found what they put in front of us.”

That was the sentence that finally hurt.

Because it did not erase what followed.

Zoe had still become Zoe.

Their daughter had remained dead.

No child had returned.

No miracle had happened.

They had simply been shown something that struck exactly where they were weakest.

Then they had spent five years living with what came afterwards.

Helen put the photograph back into the box.

Not hidden.

Not displayed.

Just back.

For now.

* * *

Zoe returned to the laptop after forty minutes.

No one mentioned the walk.

She opened one final part of the recipient profile.

Not the viewing.

Not photographs.

Only the prediction made before placement.

The system expected Helen and Brian to attach strongly.

It expected a stable household.

It expected low risk of breakdown.

And it expected something else.

Fear of losing the child once the placement had become emotionally real.

Zoe stared at that.

"They knew they'd be scared of losing me."

"They predicted it."

"Before I lived there."

"Yes."

"And that made the placement safer."

"For the people running it, yes." She understood.

No model required.

The cruelty was simple.

If Helen and Brian loved Zoe, they would have more to lose.

If Zoe loved Helen and Brian, she would have more to lose too.

The stronger the family became, the harder it would be for anyone inside it to pull at the beginning.

Zoe sat back.

"They didn't have to control us every day."

"No."

"They just had to get it started."

"Yes."

“And make sure nobody asked the wrong question.”

“Yes.”

For five years, nobody had.

Schools saw a family.

Doctors saw a family.

Neighbours saw a family.

Zoe saw a family.

Because they were one.

That was precisely what made the original act so difficult to uncover.

The lie had grown around something real.

Zoe closed RCP-0193.

For real this time.

No photographs.

No medical records.

No private letters.

No dead child’s face.

Enough.

* * *

Dinner happened in a pub where the menu contained twelve burgers and one salad.

Zoe counted.

“Twelve to one.”

Elias looked up.

“What?”

“Burgers to salad. Correct ratio.”

He closed the menu.

“I’ll have the salad.”

Zoe stared.

“You’re doing that to annoy me.”

“No.”

“That is the only explanation.”

“I want salad.”

“Which is exactly what somebody deliberately trying to annoy me would say.”

Elias ordered the salad.

Zoe considered reporting him to someone.

For twenty minutes, nothing important happened.

She ate chips.

Elias ate leaves.

Football played silently above the bar.

A man near the window appeared to be explaining to his wife why his parking fine was morally invalid.

Then Zoe said:

“I keep wanting one of them to be less guilty.”

Elias put his fork down.

“Which one?”

“Either.”

He waited.

“Then I want both of them to be worse.”

“Why?”

“Because that would be easier too.”

He nodded.

If Brian were innocent and Helen guilty, Zoe could divide them.

If both had been deceived completely, she could forgive them more easily.

If both had knowingly taken a child from a loving family while laughing about it, she could hate them.

Instead:

Brian had objected.

Then stayed.

Helen had reopened the route.

Because she believed she could give a child something valuable.

They had been told the lawful family process might not be finished.

They continued.

They had loved Zoe.

For five years. All of those things were true at the same time. Zoe pushed a chip through ketchup. “I hate complicated people.”

“You are a complicated person.”

“That is different.”

“Of course.”

“Because I’m me.”

“Compelling distinction.”

She pointed the chip at him. “That sounded sarcastic.”

“It was.”

Good. For a few seconds she was thirteen and annoyed about salad again. She needed that.

* * *

That night, sleep refused to cooperate. Zoe lay beneath a duvet too warm for the room. Elias was on the other bed. She knew he was awake because his breathing changed whenever he slept. "You awake?" "Yes." "Annoying."

"Yes."

She stared at the ceiling.

The problem was not that old memories had become false.

It was worse.

They were still true.

Helen brushing knots from her hair and apologising every time the brush pulled.

Brian letting go of the bicycle without warning and then running behind Zoe because he had lied about letting go.

Birthday cakes.

School uniforms.

Arguments.

Helen crying in the car on Zoe's first day of secondary school because she thought Zoe had already gone inside.

None of that disappeared.

But now every memory had another memory standing behind it.

A daughter Zoe had never met.

A four-year-old girl.

A lawful adoption assessment.

A refusal.

Mac.

A reopened door.

A profile.

A number.

Ninety-seven.

Zoe said:

“Do you think she looked at me and thought I was her?”

Elias took his time.

“I don’t know.”

“What do you think?”

“That the resemblance probably affected her.”

“Helpful.”

“You asked.”

“Unfortunately.”

She turned onto her side.

“What if that’s why she wanted me?”

“At the beginning?”

“Yes.”

“Possible.”

“There.”

“What?”

“Your word.”

He ignored her.

Zoe stared into the dark.

Elias said:

"Whatever Helen thought at the beginning, she still had five years to discover you weren't somebody else."

Zoe said nothing.

"She couldn't spend five years mistaking you for a four-year-old girl who died."

"You underestimate my ability to behave like a four-year-old."

"I do not."

That surprised a laugh out of her.

A small one.

Then it disappeared.

The system could manufacture an introduction.

It could use resemblance.

Grief.

Probability.

It could put the right child in front of the right wound.

It could make coincidence look like destiny.

"They manufactured fate," Zoe said.

"Yes."

She thought about that.

Then:

"But they couldn't manufacture me."

"No."

That felt different.

Clean, almost.

The system had selected characteristics.

It had predicted attachment.

It had scored her.

But it had not created the person who later hated mushrooms, argued with teachers, loved terrible fantasy novels and once refused to speak to Brian for two days because he threw away a yoghurt she had been saving.

It had not created five years of becoming herself.

That belonged to her.

Zoe closed her eyes.

One question remained.

Not why Helen and Brian.

She knew.

Not why Zoe.

She knew enough.

Not why ninety-seven.

That number finally had a face.

The unopened section was still waiting.

P3 — CONTROLLED VISUAL INTRODUCTION

Somewhere between the profile and the family was a moment when Helen and Brian had first seen her.

The archive had not yet told Zoe how.

She had refused to open it.

Tomorrow she would.

Zoe turned onto her back again.

“How did they first see me?”

Elias did not answer.

There was no answer yet.

Elias had none to give.